The Writer's Eye — Film

Watched: _____
Where: _____
First time? ☐ yes ☐ rewatch

Describe the shape it actually has. Do not check it against a template.

FILM | YEAR | WRITTEN BY | DIRECTED BY

1 AFTER THE FACT

Write the logline you would write now, not the one on the poster

The question the film is asking:

The answer it gives — or refuses to give:

2 THE SHAPE IT ACTUALLY HAS

Tick what fits, cross out what nearly fits, and write your own if none do

☐ three-act ☐ two-hander / duel ☐ kishōtenketsu ☐ jo-ha-kyū ☐ rival accounts (Rashomon) ☐ braided ensemble ☐ circular / return
☐ odyssey / picaresque ☐ slice of life ☐ mosaic of vignettes ☐ procedural ☐ frame story ☐ reverse chronology ☐ daisy chain ☐ nested / recursive
☐ one continuous day ☐ drifting / plotless

IF NONE OF THESE — DESCRIBE THE SHAPE IN YOUR OWN WORDS

RUNTIME — MARK EVERY TURN YOU FELT, NOT EVERY TURN YOU CAN NAME

start | 10% | 20% | 30% | 40% | 50% | 60% | 70% | 80% | end

The useful test is not act numbers — it is irreversibility. If nothing became impossible to undo, it was an event, not a turn.

THE TURN	≈ MIN	WHAT BECAME IMPOSSIBLE TO UNDO	WHO CAUSED IT

3 THE ENGINE

What actually kept me in the seat

☐ a question ☐ a deadline ☐ a want ☐ a relationship ☐ a mystery ☐ dread ☐ the pleasure of company ☐ a formal pattern ☐ a voice ☐ a place
☐ an argument ☐ grief

SOMETHING ELSE

When did the engine change — and did I notice at the time?

What did the film promise in its first ten minutes?

4 PEOPLE

CHARACTER	WANTS	NEEDS (AND DOES NOT KNOW IT)	WOULD NEVER SAY OUT LOUD	ENDS UP

5 ONE SCENE, TAKEN APART

Pick the one you would show someone to explain the whole film

THE SCENE | ≈ MIN | POWER AT THE START | POWER AT THE END

What is the argument underneath the words? Nobody in a good scene is discussing what the scene is about.

Where does it start — how much did they trust us to skip? And how does it get out?

What would be lost if it were cut entirely? If the answer is "nothing much," say so — that is worth knowing too.

6 LANGUAGE

Three lines I would steal:

One line that did too much work — said out loud what the film had already shown:

How does this dialogue differ from how people actually talk, and what does that buy?

7 STRUCTURE WORTH STEALING

Move it from admiration into something I can use on a Tuesday

WHAT THEY DID	HOW IT ACTUALLY WORKS	WHERE IT FITS IN SOMETHING OF MINE

8 IF I WERE REWRITING IT

Where it lost me — and would I have solved that problem the same way?

What is the film secretly about, underneath what it says it is about?

What would this be in another form — a pilot, a short story, a play, a half-hour? What breaks, and what gets better?

9 WHAT THIS SENDS ME TO NEXT

TITLE	WHY — WHAT I WANT TO WATCH THEM DO	✓

If I could ask the writer one question:

And one for the costume designer — cross-reference the other sheet:

VERDICT

☐ steal ☐ study ☐ avoid

The one thing I am taking into my own pages: